a long time to come." His objective, said the president, was peace. Khrushchev was anything but appreciative. "Miscalculation," declared the Soviet leader, was a very vague term. The United States "wanted the USSR to sit like a schoolboy with his hands on his desk." Khrushchev, for his part, was ready to misbehave.[14]

On June 4, the second day of the summit, Khrushchev used the president's concern over "miscalculation" to threaten Kennedy. Bilateral relations would be greatly affected "if the US were to misunderstand the Soviet position," he told the president. He wanted a comprehensive peace treaty to formally end the war, recognizing the existence of two German states and making West Berlin a free city. The Soviet Union was prepared to guarantee the city's free contact with the rest of the world and promised not to interfere in its internal affairs. There would be no more blockades, suggested Khrushchev. The Americans could even leave their troops there, but in that case the Soviet Union would also station its troops in the western part of the city. He expressed his desire for an agreement with Kennedy, but if it did not materialize, he was ready to sign a separate agreement with East Germany. Khrushchev made a moral argument to support his case: the Soviet Union had lost twenty million citizens in World War II, that war had to come to an end, and there was no reason to postpone the conclusion of a treaty sixteen years after the end of hostilities.

Kennedy's defense was rooted in nothing but the right of the conqueror and the importance of great-power prestige. "We are in Berlin not because of someone's sufferance. We fought our way there, although our casualties may not have been as high as the USSR's," said Kennedy. He did not specify the US losses, which stood at approximately 420,000, and were well below the Soviet numbers. "If we were expelled from that area and if we accepted the loss of our rights, no one would have any confidence in US commitments and pledges," continued the president, ignoring Khrushchev's suggestion that American troops could stay in the free city of West Berlin. "If we were to leave West Berlin, Europe would be abandoned as well," Kennedy argued. "Our leaving West Berlin would result in the US becoming isolated."

Khrushchev was furious. Returning to the issue of Soviet war losses and recapitulating his earlier argument, he put forward another ultimatum: "The